Dr Hermione Spriggs
Artist / Director
Hermione Spriggs Studio, 35a Gladesmore Road, London N156TA
hermione.spriggs@gmail.com
hermione-spriggs.com
079 71711593

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To whom it may concern,

I am writing to describe how Jason Hockman's instrument, The Archivist, was used in Worm Grunting, a sound-led short film I directed and produced, premiering on November 5th at Aesthetica Film Festival, York.

Worm Grunting was funded through the *Aesthetica x Audible Listening Pitch*, for which three filmmakers were selected through a competitive open call and pitching process. The film explores worm charming, the practice of drawing earthworms to the surface by vibrating the ground using hand-made instruments. It explores the embodied and auditory experience of earthworms, who have no ears and instead experience sonic vibration through their whole-body cochlea.

I asked Jason to work on the film because of his expertise in granular synthesis. Our collaborative process began with a dialogue around two parallel processes: a worm digesting and "particulating" earth, reconstituting it into a more nutrient-rich material, and the way that granular synthesis performs to particulate and regenerate sound.

I wanted parts of the film's sound to feel otherworldly, to render sound as it might be experienced for worms who digest the earth as they move through it. Achieving this involves a degree of abstraction, repetition, recursion and decay. Jason's Archivist keeps a running memory of the sound played into it. Reaching further back brings back a longer stretch of sound at lower quality, like old tape or an early sampler. In its tape mode, recordings also wear as they are played, growing quieter and duller and starting to drop out. It also enables us to "zoom in" to sound, stretching a sample and slowing tempo while generating a rich sonic ground. In the sections of the film where we are at ground level in the world of the worms, we used the Archivist to granulate field recordings, altering them in a way that explodes time and scale and brings the viewer closer to the worm.

Jason and I worked in close collaboration through a series of experimental sessions where we explored the application of the Archivist in the context of the film. This exchange began before the film's shooting took place and was integral to the film's development. The instrument was then carefully calibrated by Jason for the purposes of the film, while the scoring of the film evolved in response to the instrument's capabilities. The resulting sound world of *Worm Grunting* emerged from this iterative, collaborative process.

Worm Grunting premieres at the Aesthetica Film Festival in York on 5 November 2026, in a special event featuring films commissioned for the Listening Pitch. An initial press announcement featuring this new work is available here: https://www.asff.co.uk/2026-listening-pitch-winners-announced/.

Aesthetica Film Festival is a prestigious BAFTA and BIFA-qualifying international film festival held annually in York, UK, hosts 26,000+ visitors including international filmmakers, VR experts, and industry delegates from more than 60 countries. The premiere of Worm Grunting takes place at one

of the festival's larger venues, York City Screen Screen 1, with a seating capacity of 203 (including four wheelchair accessible spaces).

The film has been invited to screen through Photoworks (Brighton) later this year and is being submitted for screening at a number of other film festivals internationally. There is an ongoing conversation around returning the film to Sopchoppy, the small town in Florida where it was shot, for the Sopchoppy Worm Gruntin' Festival in April 2027. Jason and I will continue to work together on future projects, including a second short film focussing on the parallel practice of "worm charming" in the UK, currently in post-production, and in a time-based art installation with the Archivist employed as a real-time generator of granulated sound in response to environmental inputs relating to worm behaviour.

I greatly look forward to working with Jason on the future stages of this collaboration. I am happy to confirm any of the above.

Yours sincerely,



Dr Hermione Spriggs

Independent Artist & Scholar
AoOA (The Anthropology of Other Animals)